



Esports fandom: Esports fans watch the 2025 League of Legends Champions Korea Finals at Inspire Arena in Incheon, South Korea.

GETTYIMAGES

Aichi-Nagoya, where they will represent India in League of Legends.

For most Indian athletes heading to a major multi-sport event, preparation involves the familiar rituals of elite sport: camps, coaches, physiotherapists, teammates living together, training facilities and months spent in one another's company. For India's League of Legends team, preparation looks very different. None of them makes a living from the game. Their training ground is not an academy but the internet; their meeting room is *Discord*. They've never hung out together outside of competition, when games are played over LAN. The only time they'll play together in person before Aichi-Nagoya is when they actually reach it.

League of Legends is a multiplayer online battle arena (MOBA). Five players work together to destroy the opposing team's base, each taking on a different role and making decisions individually and collectively, often in fractions of a second. A player's ability to control his champion, what players call "micro," is only the foundation.

"You can't just play with the person if he's just good. You have to have similar goals," says Shenoy.

That understanding has been hard to build for India's players, who have never had access to the infrastructure available in the game's strongest countries. The team exists because

Akshaj decided India's best individuals should stop playing separately, scattered across different teams, often alongside friends rather than the strongest players available. So, in 2022, he started reaching out. There was no scouting programme, no academy, no centralised system; they found one another online. The group became one of the strongest in India's League scene, and when the game was introduced as a medal sport at the Asian Games, they qualified and competed in Hangzhou, finishing fifth.

Akshaj knows how different his team looks from the rest of India's contingent.

"At the last Asian Games in Hangzhou, we were at the Games village food court when one of the Indian track and field athletes came up to us and said, 'You guys are from the esports team, right?'" Akshaj recalls. "I was like, 'How did you guess?' And he told me it was because we were the only team that came in different shapes and sizes. That was pretty funny, but it was also very accurate."

The players don't look, live, or train the way most people imagine an athlete should. But the Games gave them a reason to think of themselves as athletes representing a country, and for some, the first real evidence to their families that this was more than a hobby.

Mihir's parents had long struggled to understand how serious his gaming was, until the National Anti-Doping Agency turned up at their house before the 2023 Asian Games. "I had been informed that I would probably be tested at some point, but

still it was startling when officials arrived at my home in Delhi and told me I had to pee in a cup while they watched," he recalls. "For my parents, it was probably a weird matter of pride. The fact that I was drug tested actually gave some legitimacy to the whole thing," he says.

The players are legitimate enough to be drug-tested like any other athletes at a major multi-sport event, but they aren't yet playing in an ecosystem capable of supporting all of them as full-time professionals. Their choice of practice time, late into the night, is simply the only time they all have to spare.

Mihir has made a deliberate choice not to pursue gaming full-time. "I do consider myself a professional sports person, from a mentality perspective," he says. He's been playing for 13 years, and the competitive drive is still there: "I have a drive and a passion in me that I want to get as good as these guys and I want to beat them someday." But he says, "I don't think anyone does sports for money; you do it for the love of the game... it was just becoming a bit apparent to me that I will not be able to sustain the kind of lifestyle I want. In this game at least."

Rahul Bisht, a BITS Pilani computer science graduate and, at 29, the oldest in the squad, has spent eight to ten years as a product designer, working on projects including the initial design of the Paytm card machine. He now runs his own startup, but gaming has remained the one constant. "There's no other time in which to practise other than late at night. That's when we are all free. We'll practise together until about 12 am. After that I'll play a few games on my own. Then I'll work for the next few hours. I probably sleep for about four or five hours a night," he says.

Sanindhya's situation takes that contradiction a step further. He works for Telecommunications Consultants India Ltd. (TCIL), a government company, and is currently posted in Mauritius, where he builds telecommunications infrastructure by day and prepares for the Asian Games in Japan by night. Last year, a damaged submarine fibre optic cable